Descriptive Paragraph

The big idea

A **descriptive paragraph** paints a **word picture** of a person, place, object or event so vividly that the reader can see, hear and feel it. In CBSE Class 9 you are usually asked to write about **100–120 words** describing a person, place or event, often with given cues or a picture. Good description depends on **sensory details**, **logical order** and **precise vocabulary**.

Structure

1. **Topic sentence**: introduce the subject and your overall impression.
2. **Body**: details in a clear order: for a place, spatial order (outside to inside, near to far); for a person, appearance → qualities → habits; for an event, chronological order.
3. **Concluding sentence**: sum up your feelings or the impression left.

SHOW, DON'T TELL

"My grandmother is kind" tells. "My grandmother keeps a tin of laddoos for every child who visits" shows. Use examples and actions.

Describing a person

- **Physical appearance**: height, face, eyes, hair, dress (do not overdo it).
- **Personality and qualities**: honest, cheerful, disciplined, with examples.
- **Habits, interests** and how the person influences you.
- Tense: usually **simple present** for a living person (She **teaches** us maths).

Describing a place

- Location and first impression.
- **Five senses**: sights, sounds, smells, textures, tastes.
- People, activity, atmosphere at different times.
- Tense: **simple present** (The market **buzzes** with voices).

Describing an event

- What, when, where, who; sequence of happenings; highlight; your feelings.
- Tense: **simple past** (The annual day **began** with a prayer).

SAMPLE: A BUSY RAILWAY STATION (ABOUT 110 WORDS)

The railway station near my house is a world in itself. As soon as I enter, the smell of tea and samosas greets me from the stalls on the platform. Announcements boom over loudspeakers, mixing with the shouts of porters in red shirts who balance heavy suitcases on their heads. Families sit on their luggage, while children press their faces to the window of the bookstall. When a train thunders in, the platform comes alive: passengers rush to the doors, vendors call out "chai, chai", and friends wave goodbye. Within minutes the train pulls away and a strange calm returns. The station never fails to remind me how busy and colourful life is.

Useful vocabulary

Senses	Words
Sight	glittering, towering, crowded, faded, lush
Sound	buzzing, chirping, roaring, hushed, clatter
Smell	fragrant, musty, aroma of, whiff of

Senses	Words
Feelings	serene, chaotic, nostalgic, awe-struck

COMMON ERRORS

Writing a list of facts with no feelings; mixing tenses; exceeding the word limit; describing irrelevant details; forgetting a title when one is asked.

SCORING POINTS

Marks are usually for **content**, **organisation** and **accuracy/fluency**. Use all the cues given, add two or three sensory details, use linkers (as soon as, beside, in the middle, finally), and keep within the word limit.

Practice

1. Describe your favourite teacher in 100–120 words.
2. Describe a village fair you visited (cues: stalls, swings, crowds, food, your feelings).
3. Describe the scene at your school on Sports Day.

Quick recap

- Topic sentence → ordered details → concluding impression.
- Use the five senses and specific examples.
- Present tense for persons/places; past tense for events; stick to the word limit.

Practice questions

1. The first sentence of a descriptive paragraph that introduces the subject is called the

   (a) concluding sentence (b) topic sentence (c) supporting detail (d) title

2. Which order is best when describing a place?

   (a) Random order (b) Alphabetical order (c) Spatial order, such as near to far (d) Reverse chronological order

3. Which sentence "shows" rather than "tells"?

   (a) My father is very hardworking. (b) The garden is beautiful. (c) The garden glows with red roses and buzzing bees. (d) The fair was nice.

4. Which tense is usually used to describe a past event such as Annual Day?

   (a) Simple present (b) Future perfect (c) Present continuous (d) Simple past

5. "The aroma of freshly baked bread" appeals to which sense?

   (a) Sight (b) Hearing (c) Touch (d) Smell

6. Which is a common mistake in descriptive writing?

   (a) Mixing tenses without reason (b) Using sensory words (c) Writing a concluding sentence (d) Following a logical order

7. Write a descriptive paragraph (100–120 words) on "A Rainy Day in My Town".

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. c 4. d 5. d 6. a 7. see notes